certain people were bribed.[62] Ultimately, the Indian government proved to be correct with its warning in 1918 that Britain should seek the friendship of the Persian people before trying to conclude an agreement with the Persian government. In a letter to Montagu in December 1920, Chelmsford could not resist gloating slightly:

We have carefully abstained from saying ‘I told you so’, but anyone who takes the trouble to peruse our telegrams from the very beginning of the Persian negotiations will see that we have been strenuous opponents of the Curzon policy and that we wished to confine our interference in Persian matters within much smaller limits.[63]

In ignoring the forces of nationalism within Persian society, Curzon and Cox had made a grave error. They had believed that any opposition would be inconsequential and easily subdued. Curzon appeared to believe that the majority of the Persian public still saw Britain as they had done prior to 1907 – as a friend and protector. Perhaps Cox was at fault for not enlightening his superior about Persian feeling after 1918. However, Cox appears to have seen what he wanted to see when it came to analysing Persian sentiment towards Britain. Both men had failed to appreciate that the days when governments could entirely ignore public opinion on foreign relations had long gone, even within the relatively politically backward nations of Asia.

The ignominy of Britain’s position in Persia in 1920 was further demonstrated by its complete impotence when it came to the Cossack Division. A key part of the Anglo-Persian Agreement had been the idea of creating a Persian force that would assimilate the Cossack Division and the South Persian Rifles, thereby relieving the British government of the financial responsibilities for these troops. With the Persian government refusing to enact the agreement, however, this project was being held in limbo, leaving the Cossack Division still active in Persia. Indeed, given the shortage of troops in Persia in 1920, the Division was to prove invaluable following the Bolshevik landings at Enzeli. For Britain, the Division